

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

TEST CASE?

Ex-Union minister **Rajeev Chandrasekhar**, 60, has been handpicked by the BJP's central leadership to head its faction-ridden Kerala unit. The tech-savvy business mogul will lead the BJP charge in this year's local body polls and the 2026 assembly election. The appointment, though, has not gone down well with senior state leaders, who remain sceptical of what he can deliver. Already memes are out of him bumbling away in Malayalam, some of it, sources say, put out by partymen themselves. Rajeev's last electoral battle, against Congress MP Shashi Tharoor in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, ended in a narrow defeat in Thiruvananthapuram—an outcome that underscores both his potential and the uphill challenge ahead. His surprise elevation, though, has got tongues wagging: is the BJP quietly test-launching a CM candidate for Kerala?

The Biggest Jinx

Uttarakhand CM **Pushkar Singh Dhami,** who is juggling a staggering 39 departments, has been lobbying with the BJP leadership in Delhi for a cabinet expansion (five berths are lying vacant in the 12-seat cabinet). The central leadership has asked him to submit performance cards of all the ministers—a clear signal that a reshuffle is imminent. That spells danger too—the government has completed three years in office, and the anti-Dhami camp is back in action. Uttarakhand's history hasn't been kind to CMs—only one has completed a full term. Dhami broke one jinx by becoming the first CM to return to power. Can he beat another, become the first BJP CM to complete a full five-year term?



ARUN KUMAR

PARTY MINUS POLITICS



In a first, Jammu and Kashmir CM **Omar Abdullah** and his father, National Conference (NC) president Farooq Abdullah, attended an Iftar party hosted by arch-rival and PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti in Jammu on March 23. As the holy month of Ramzan nears its end, this unusual show of camaraderie underscores how religion can bring opponents together, especially after all the bitterness from the poll campaign last year. Gen Next seems to be getting along too—Mehbooba's daughter Iltija and Omar's sons were seen together at another Iftar party in Srinagar.

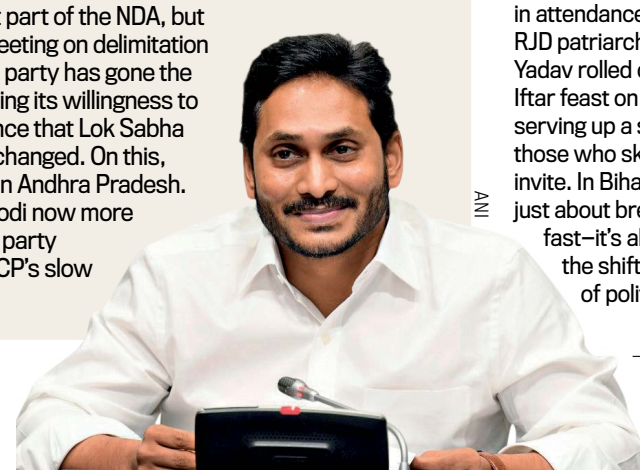
Guess Who's Not Coming to Dinner

They say the way to a man's heart is through his stomach. But in Bihar's political kitchen, not every feast hits the mark. CM **Nitish Kumar's** grand Daawat-e-Iftar on March 23 at his 1, Anne Marg residence saw half a dozen Muslim organisations give him the cold shoulder, protesting the JD(U)'s support to the Waqf Amendment Bill. Still, the turnout wasn't bad, with VIPs like governor Arif Mohammad Khan in attendance. Meanwhile, RJD patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav rolled out his own Iftar feast on March 24, serving up a spread for those who skipped Nitish's invite. In Bihar, Iftar isn't just about breaking the fast—it's about tasting the shifting flavours of political loyalty.



Pressure and Pivot

Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's YSRCP isn't part of the NDA, but he still skipped the March 22 joint action meeting on delimitation called by Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin. In fact, the party has gone the other way, written to PM Narendra Modi signalling its willingness to go by Union home minister Amit Shah's assurance that Lok Sabha seats for the southern states would remain unchanged. On this, Jagan finds himself aligned with the ruling TDP in Andhra Pradesh. But the subtext is hard to miss—Jagan needs Modi now more than ever, as he faces mounting pressure from party defections and a slew of CBI cases. Is the YSRCP's slow decline nudging Jagan closer to the NDA orbit?



ANI

Kaushik Deka with Jeemon Jacob, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Kaleem Geelani, Amitabh Srivastava and Amarnath K. Menon